

A Donkey Herder to Lead Us

When I was young, singing songs like “I’m in the Lord’s Army,” I imagined God as the leader of the army, sword in hand, flag of the Kingdom of Heaven raised high. Throw some chariots of fire in the background even. Was that just me? I was ready to take on the world and light some fires in His name. Or, at least I thought I was supposed to be.

I was ready to take on the world and light some fires in His name.

It was something similar to the scene in *The Return of the King* when Aragorn rallies the troops at the gates of Mordor, and even two hobbits run into battle, tiny swords in hand, inspired by his leadership.

Yet, what is it that made Aragorn such a great king? (I apologize if you’re unfamiliar with these references.) It wasn’t just his ability to slay the enemy or lead the armies in battle. As powerful as those things can be, there were many soldiers and commanders and kings doing similar things—just like there are in history and our current world, not just in fiction.

What made him the best of leaders and good men is when he took a knee to the smallest of heroes. The hobbits in particular. The unexpected individuals who lived with heart, courage, dedication, and love. Aragorn could fight and battle, but he had the humility and the humanity to know when to stop and lay honor at the feet of another.

These archetypes of leadership carry over into the stories of King Saul and David. Israel, wanting not just a king, but a king who made them look more like the rest of the world. Those kings who knew how to rally troops and fight—but in whose name?

Kings who look the part, but do they have the true heart?

So then came Saul. A donkey herder, no less. You can’t say God doesn’t have a sense of humor as God sends stubborn Israel the king they were asking for—or at least He doesn’t stop it. A king who made them, more or less, look a whole lot more like the kingdoms around them than the Kingdom of Heaven. A king who looked the part, but wasn’t the one, as we’ll soon see, to go out *before* the armies and slay the giant, or humble himself before the people or God he was supposed to be fighting for.

Kings who look the part, but do they have the true heart?

And then there’s David. So young his father doesn’t even have him in the room to line up before Samuel. The youngest brother, probably the smallest. The shepherd boy out with his sisters, tossing rocks, maybe holding a staff as he ran and skipped home, suddenly anointed as the King of Israel.

A kid. A wallflower. Not the second born or third or most remarkably strong from the sound of it. The unexpected son who Samuel saw the heart of, and if you know the Text later on, a heart that did its best to honor the name of God.

Think back to our images of the desert in Session 1. What are the characteristics and attributes of a good shepherd? They go before their sheep. They lead with gentleness and love and the sound of their own voice. No coercion and intimidation. They use the crook in their shepherd's staff to rescue their sheep, to bring them closer to him, and only use it as a weapon to protect their sheep from predators.

Perhaps that's why, in this image of the Lord's army, I no longer see a raging commander or King glowing in mithril light. Instead, I see a shepherd with his staff—there to protect, lead, comfort, direct. Out in front of his sheep, no hard-hitting power, but the beautiful sound of His voice to teach them how to look more like Him.

What are the characteristics and attributes of a good shepherd?

A leader—a *good* leader—leads with love. They lead with a power that moves people to action with the very sound of their voice. A call that makes us want to move in closer because that is where we belong, where we feel we are most ourselves, and no sheep is left on the roadside—not even the stubborn goats.

This is what Saul couldn't see, and David, although not perfect, did. He had the wisdom and humility at this point in the story to kneel and honor not just another, but to do so before the living God.

So, what kind of leader will we choose? What kind of leader does God want us to follow?

PRAYER

*You've called me to be different.
To choose love over hate. Peace over chaos.
Hospitality over power. Shalom over empire.
It's difficult, and sometimes I miss the mark,
when the rest of the world lives so differently.
Help me never to forget that You go before me,
and remain, always, beside me.
May I remember that you have set me apart
to be and to bring Your Kingdom to all.*

Amen

THE FOUR PILLARS

BEMA Discipleship is built on four pillars; a **Four-Pillared Perspective** to help us remember **to elevate the words of God** (not ours) and help us identify the principles that we see recurring in the story of God's people.

Here are some applications for this episode echoing the ideas of the four pillars:



TEXT

What Text might you spend more time in? What in the Text previously do we know about shepherds that might give us more insight into David's versus Saul's character?



COMMUNITY

How are you, or your community, choosing to lead others? Through the qualities of a shepherd, or something that looks and sounds more like the world?



DISCIPLESHIP

Who are you modeling this kind of leadership for? Who can you invite to come alongside you in not just studying the Text, but in hallowing the name of God?



WRESTLING

What are you wrestling with in this story? Israel asking for a King? Why God let them have Saul and didn't just wait for David? Remember, questions are good!



Are you a music listener?

Listen along to our BEMA Music Playlists on Spotify.

Song suggestions? Send them to bemabesorah@gmail.com.



BEMA SESSION 2



MEDITATION & PRAYER

REFLECTION, APPLICATION & IMPACT

There are three emphases that we are always thinking about in terms of application at BEMA. These may be stated explicitly at times, but often we will want you to do the work of finding ways to connect the dots to the things we are learning. Much of this is what makes the work of BEMA distinct as a ministry of Impact Campus Ministries.

CREATING A SPACE

SPIRITUAL FORMATION

*True success is developing intimacy with God. In Session 1, we encountered the idea of “Creating Space for God” in our lives. We believe that **if we do our part of creating that space, God will fill it** as He desires. You’re already doing this as you dive into the Text and jump into a place to discuss. God will meet you in these places! Look for places the Holy Spirit can do work in and through you as you go about your everyday life.*

CONSIDERING CAMPUS

YOUNG PEOPLE FOCUS

***We believe that young adults are shaping the future of this world.** Jesus modeled a ministry of discipling young adults, and that approach has and will work. If you are a college student who is listening, we want this material to be directly helpful to your pursuits. If you are not a college student, we want to challenge you to come alongside one and work together.*

SACRED STATION

THEOLOGY OF WORK

*This isn’t only for church or Bible study; this is about what we do every day. How we do our job and how it may take advantage of or bring life to others is something God says is central to our presence in the world. Justice is very much something God cares about. Does our physical work (our 9–5 job) bring shalom or chaos? Does it exploit creation? The way we manage our employees, interact with customers or coworkers, care for our children, or create products can provide relief to others. **The work we do every day is sacred and matters!***